



The Apollo Soyuz Test Project Crew Deke Slayton, Thomas Stafford, Vance Brand, Alexei Leonov, Waleri Kubassov

A few hours later it was the crew members who were literally shaking hands, exchanging hugs and ceremonial gifts, including US, Soviet and United Nations flags, commemorative plaques, medallions, certificates and tree seeds.

The crews received a congratulatory message from Soviet premier Leonid Brezhnev and a phone call from US President Gerald Ford.

Apollo Commander Stafford had another unique cultural exchange for the cosmonauts. He'd gotten country music star Conway Twitty to record 'Privet Radost', a Russian version of his hit 'Hello, Darlin'. About an hour before the two craft undocked, the song was played from orbit and heard all over the world.

The Apollo crew returned to Earth on July 19, and their Russian counterparts two days later. It would be two decades until the countries teamed up again with the Shuttle-Mir program, but the seed was planted. As Brand said, "I really believe that we were sort of an example ... to the countries. We were a little of a spark or a foot in the door that started better communications." 